



Whatever happened to ICQ?

Well it's back in the game with a shiny new avatar ICQ7, that integrates social networking. Ah nostalgia...

Networking altruism

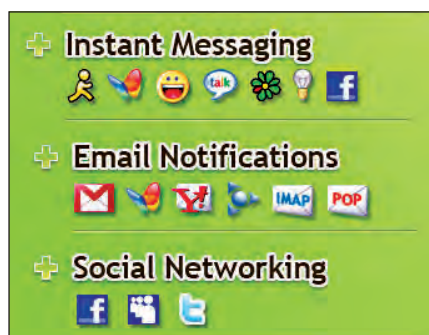
An entirely social networking based viral campaign promoted through sites like Facebook and Twitter earned more than \$3 million for Red Cross relief work in Haiti

Feature

managing multiple email accounts, it also allows you to receive updates and send status messages on your Facebook, Twitter, MySpace and LinkedIn accounts. It has a real-time Newsfeed box with notifications. Digsby (www.digsby.com) is more than just an application for social networking. Its lack of features such as Lists and Search is compensated by its email and chat features.

Facebook Notifier, fbQuick, Scrap Notifier are some unofficial apps that notify you. An application such as Growl for Windows or Snarl could integrate most of your networks.

Of course, the above Desktop Clients for various networks are merely some among several. Depending on your level of functionality, there are many clients (especially for Twitter) out there that you could tweak and customise to suit



Digsby, one stop for all your networking online

your purpose. For several users, the amount of RAM an application consumes is a major factor while weighing its merits.

Moving over from the desktop, there're several users who spend hours online browsing web sites. Hence, a browser add-on should fit the bill nicely. For one, there's the Facebook Toolbar for Firefox. Developed by Facebook (<http://developers.facebook.com/toolbar/>), it allows you to search Facebook from anywhere and get notified of new pokes, friend requests, messages, invitation, wall posts, profile updates, photos and everything else. You can also open the Facebook Sidebar with a click of an icon to chat with those online. Possibly the most useful tool for compulsive content sharers is the option to share on Facebook the webpage you are viewing currently.

For Browser add-ons, we recommend trying out either Chrome or Firefox. Though Chrome extensions are a relatively newer addition, and may not have the varied options that Firefox does, they're worth a try. For Firefox add-ons, go to <https://addons.mozilla.org/en-US/firefox/>.

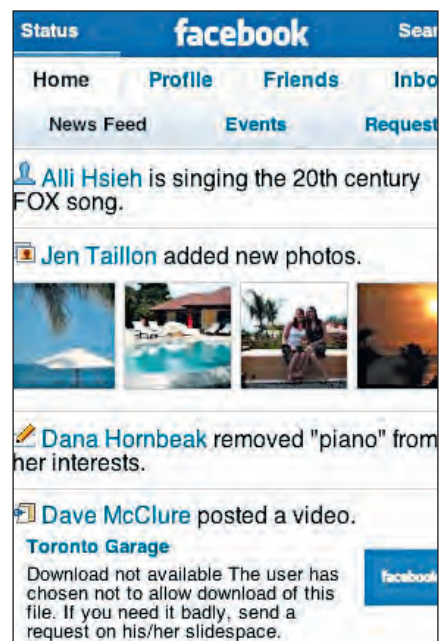
Echofon (<http://echofon.com/twitter/firefox/>) is by far our favourite when it comes to browser based Twitter clients. With three windows (one for timeline, one for mentions and direct messages), it also has multiple account support. It rests at the bottom of the browser with an unread message count and has a pop-up feature for new messages.

Yoono is another multiple social-networking one-stop destination that allows a sidebar extension to Firefox. It allows you to update and monitor Facebook, Twitter, MySpace among others and has IM features allowing you to add Yahoo!, Gtalk and MSN.

Check <http://chrome.google.com/extensions> for social networking extensions that you can plug into Google Chrome.

For those who use iGoogle or the Google Desktop application, there are also widgets and gadgets that you can use to view Twitter, Facebook and other applications. Several IM clients such as Meebo and Imo.im also allow you to integrate Facebook chat and Twitter updates. Gmail has TwitterGadget (www.twittergadget.com) where you can access Twitter right from Gmail. There's a Facebook gadget that works on iGoogle and Gmail (<http://www.brianngo.net/ig/facebook.xml>) (though not an official one). Orkut, being a Google product integrates quite well with Gmail with options such as Orkut birthdays and more.

After browsers and desktop apps, there's the mobile. Facebook has two mobile sites – one for normal mobile browsers (m.facebook.com) and the other for touch-enabled phones (x.facebook.com). Similarly Orkut, Twitter and LinkedIn have mobile versions. The typical URL for most web sites with a mobile friendly version is m.<web site>.com. So you have m.twitter.com, m.orkut.com and so on. With Twitter, there are also other sites which have a better functionality when it comes to accessing them via mobile. Few examples include <http://dabr.co.uk>, <http://m.slandr>.



Connect on your handset with Facebook's mobile site

net, <http://m.tweete.net> among several others. These offer some functionalities that the mobile Twitter site does not, such as the ability to disable images from loading and present links as plain text. They have standard features such as bookmark as favourite, retweet and reply.

With Mobile apps, it's a harder list to gather. There's the standard one offered by companies themselves. An official Facebook app, for example, comes built-in with certain Nokia phones. Orkut also has a mobile application. For Twitter, there's a huge market with loads of competition each vying for the top space. You'd have the best of choices if you owned an iPhone since most networks have an app custom built for it. There're also several third-party applications. Most apps, however, are platform dependent. Fring seems to be a popular one across platforms.

On the whole, the options out there are several. The number of ways you can access your favourite social networking site are numerous. We'd recommend trying one of every kind. If at home, use a Desktop client, if at work, use an inline browser application or a web-based offshoot, and while travelling, try both the mobile application and try accessing it via mobile browser. See which suites you the best. It's not just about convenience and customisation, it's also a lot of fun. **d**